

Generational Sin

To the Elders of the Duncanville Bible Church¹

Two of our elders made public reference last Sunday (10/22/89) to “generational sin”, and this gave me a handle on a situation in the church that has been troubling me for some time. Generational sin? Yes! But not only within families. There is generational sin in individual churches, in schools, in denominations and across wider segments of the Church. One very serious generational sin that is endemic across wide areas of the conservative/evangelical community at large is the idolatry that elevates human reason above the revealed Word of God. This idolatry expresses itself on many fronts, but perhaps the foundational one relates to the very Text of Scripture itself—I refer to the mentality that constantly calls into question the very wording of the Text, thereby undermining confidence in its integrity and authority.

Let me give a concrete, specific example of what I am talking about. A number of weeks ago our pastor emended the Text of 1 Corinthians 8:3 from the pulpit. Instead of “*if anyone loves God this one is known by Him*” he suggested that perhaps we should read “*if anyone loves God this one knows*”. Since no printed Greek text has what he suggested I felt led of the Lord to warn him that such a proceeding was not advisable. His answer was to direct me to Gordon Fee’s commentary on 1 Corinthians, which was the source for what he had done. Fee’s commentary on 1 Corinthians 8:2-3 furnishes an unusually blatant example of the idolatry I have referred to. Consider:

The correct Text of 1 Corinthians 8:2-3, as attested by some 95% of the Greek manuscripts, reads as follows: Εἰ δὲ τις δοκεῖ εἰδέναι [86%] τι, οὐδὲπω οὐδὲν ἐγνώκε καθὼς δει γινῶναι. Εἰ δὲ τις ἀγαπᾷ τὸν θεόν, οὗτος ἐγνώσται ὑπ’ αὐτοῦ. The eclectic text presently in vogue, being followed by NIV, NASB, LB, etc., is based on a handful of Egyptian witnesses and reads like this: Εἰ ... τις δοκεῖ ἐγνώκεναι τί οὐπω ... ἐγνώ καθὼς δει γινῶναι. Εἰ δὲ τις ἀγαπᾷ τὸν θεόν, οὗτος ἐγνώσται ὑπ’ αὐτοῦ. The points at issue are underlined. It is the eclectic text that Fee uses as his starting point and is pleased to call the ‘standard text’. Had Fee recognized the correct text he could scarcely have written as he did. (But to do so he would have had to reject all that he was taught on the subject of New Testament textual criticism.) But he was not satisfied even with his ‘standard’ text—he proposes to emend it by omission in three places (see his page 367), and he does so on the basis of a single Greek MS, P⁴⁶. His text would be: Εἰ τις

¹ It broke up years ago.